

Beginnings and endings

Not all melodies begin on the first beat of the measure. In fact, many begin on the last beat. Some examples of these are shown here.

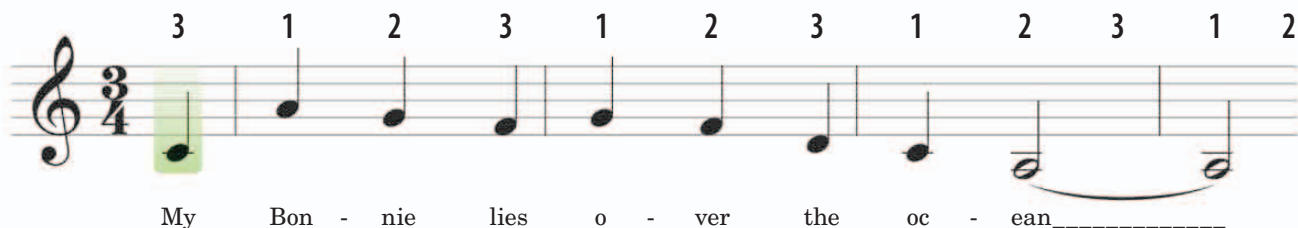
Upbeats

An upbeat is the last beat of the measure, especially at the beginning of a piece (or section of a piece). The name describes how a conductor indicates that beat—with an upward movement, in preparation for a clear downward gesture (the downbeat) at the start of the next measure. Many tunes begin on an upbeat, including the hymn “Amazing Grace,” “Hey Jude” by the Beatles, and the three examples shown below.



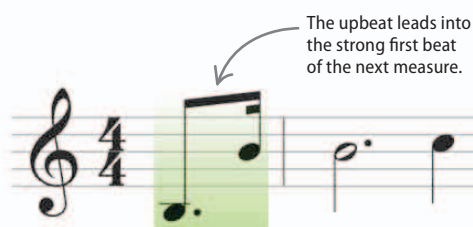
▽ “Auld Lang Syne”

“Auld Lang Syne” is a famous tune that starts on an upbeat, the fourth beat of the measure.



▽ “My Bonnie Lies Over the Ocean”

The words of a song may determine if the music has an upbeat—if they lead from an unstressed syllable to a stressed one, for example.



◁ Chopin's Prelude No. 4

An instrumental tune may also begin with an upbeat, as seen in the opening of Chopin's Prelude No. 4.

SEE ALSO

◀ 24–25 Beats and measures

Writing your own melody 112–113 ▶

Repeats 154–155 ▶

The conductor 186–187 ▶